

underworld. This is the law made by the Fates at the beginning of time, and it cannot be changed.”

Persephone knew the law, too, and had resisted touching the food in Hades’ palace. By now, though, she had been in the underworld for a long time and hunger gnawed at her belly.

*When Persephone saw a pomegranate sitting in a bowl, it looked so delicious that she could not resist.*

Persephone ate just seven of the fruit’s seeds, but it was seven too many. “Hah! Now you’ll have to stay with me forever!” laughed Hades. Zeus knew, however, that he had to find a compromise—he could not let Demeter go on causing crops to wither. He decided that since Persephone had eaten so little, she would only have to spend six months of the year in the underworld. The other six months she could return to her mother. This is how the seasons began. Demeter’s sadness at Persephone’s absence caused plants to die in the fall, but they regrew at her joy on her daughter’s return in the spring.

